



Homecoming goal: Ekta Bhyan in action during the Women's Club Throw F-51 final at the World Para Athletics Championships in Kobe in May 2024. She won gold, and now carries that momentum into her first Worlds on home soil in New Delhi. GETTY IMAGES

event, the F51 Women's Club Throw, was dropped from the programme in 2022. That was disappointing. Still, sport teaches you to reset. I reminded myself that every competition matters, whether it's the Asian Games or the World Championships. My category will

return at the Los Angeles Paralympics in 2028, and I'm determined to win a medal there.

Over the past four years, I've stayed consistent: gold medals at the National Championships, a bronze at the Asian Para Games, and medals at the World Championships, including gold and bronze in Paris in 2023. This season, I won gold at the Indian Open Paralympic Championships and followed up with silver at the India Open.

Now, in Delhi, I have a number in my mind — one I keep visualising every time I train. My personal best is 21.5m, and I'm intent on

improving that. For three years, I haven't missed a single day of training. Mornings are for the gym, evenings for outdoor practice, carefully scheduled because thermoregulation is a big challenge after a spinal injury. With only 40 per cent lung capacity and limited use of my muscles, every session requires careful management. My shoulders are my strongest asset; my biceps are okay but my triceps, forearms and wrists are very weak, and my fingers have no strength at all. But I work with what I have.

It hasn't been easy. I always need two people to help me with daily routines — transferring from wheelchair to car, reaching the ground, managing travel. Public transport is out of the question, and a car has to accommodate me, my wheelchair, and my assistants. That means bearing the expense of three people, not one.

The harder struggle, though, is mindsets. People with disabilities are still not seen as part of the mainstream.

Accessibility remains the biggest barrier to education, work, and independence. When we travel overseas, public spaces and transport are usually wheelchair accessible.

That's not the case in India. I can't imagine myself travelling by bus or train. Because of this lack of accessibility, people with disabilities are denied opportunities to be independent — to continue their education, find employment, or pursue sport. It remains one of the biggest barriers we face.

That is why visibility in sport is so powerful. After Rio, Tokyo, and Paris, I've seen how Paralympic sport is gaining recognition.

The World Championships in Delhi will be another step forward; not just for me, but for thousands of para athletes who will finally be celebrated for their effort.

I am, of course, aiming for a medal. But more than that, I am looking forward to a celebration of inclusion.

As told to Jonathan Selvaraj